

LUPRA (LUBRA / LUBRAK)

Hidden Bon village in the Panda Khola valley · One of Mustang's last all-Bon villages · 14 households/residents

PAGE 1 — PLANETARY DIMENSION

GEOGRAPHY & LANDSCAPE

- Elevation: 2,950–3,000 m a.s.l. (OpenStreetMap)
- Nestled in the Panda Khola gorge, a tributary of the Kali Gandaki River
- Part of the Baragaon region, one of 19 communities in Lower Mustang
- Situated between Jomsom (~7 km south) and Kagbeni (3 km north)
- Not on the main Annapurna Circuit road; mostly accessible by foot or rough track
- Tightly packed flat-roofed mud houses typical of trans-Himalayan vernacular architecture
- Outer walls plastered in red and white clay in the Baragaon tradition
- Lupra Pass (~4,180 m) connects the village to the Muktinath side
- Name origin: 'Lu' (serpent spirit) + 'Pra' (cliff) — refers to snakeskin-textured rock faces opposite the Panda Khola

CLIMATE & WEATHER

- Rain-shadow area behind the Annapurna–Dhaulagiri ranges; semi-arid conditions
- Short growing season; strong afternoon winds up the Kali Gandaki corridor
- Cold winters with snow; high diurnal temperature range
- Warming trends consistent with wider Himalayan pattern (high altitudes warming faster)
- Changing precipitation: reduced snowfall and altered monsoon behaviour
- Reported increase in frequency of flash floods, with multiple events observed in recent monsoon seasons
- Droughts increasingly reported in surrounding Mustang communities

BIODIVERSITY

Fauna

- Livestock central to village life: goats, sheep, horses, cows, chickens, dzo (yak-cattle cross)
- Dzo better suited to altitude than pure cattle; used for ploughing and transport
- Limited documented data on wild fauna; high-altitude species likely present in surrounding areas
- Crops: barley, buckwheat, millet, potatoes, kidney beans, vegetables
- Orchards: apples, apricots, walnuts walnut trees especially significant (founder's tree survives)
- Main farmland on terraces south of the village, not on the valley floor
- Vegetation sparse; highly dependent on stream irrigation from Panda Khola

Water

- Panda Khola is the primary water source small in dry season, dangerous in monsoon
- Glacial meltwater feeds the stream; overgrazing on upper slopes reduces water retention
- Reported to have risen significantly (in some estimates up to ~12 m in recent years)
- Rising riverbed is the defining environmental threat to the village's future

HAZARDS & DISASTERS

Flash Floods and Riverbed Rise

- Primary and growing threat; frequency has increased to multiple events per monsoon
- Each flood deposits sediment that sets like concrete, raising the riverbed
- 2017: large flood washed away a significant area of terraced farmland permanently
- Reduces available labour for farming and cultural upkeep

- Direct threat to Bon priesthood succession system and ritual continuity

Extreme Cold

- Hard winters limit mobility, agricultural work, and access to services
- Altitude-related health risks (AMS, hypothermia, respiratory illness)
- Healthcare access severely limited due to remoteness

Pasture and Soil Degradation

- Overgrazing on slopes above the Panda Khola reduces hillside water retention
- Loose topsoil more easily carried downstream, worsening flood sediment loads
- Loss of pasture quality affects livestock productivity

Out-Migration

- 2021: severe flood; two families displaced from damaged homes for several months
- Youth leaving for education and work; ageing resident Population
- Farmland loss is largely irreversible once covered by hardened sediment
- Village is actively discussing full relocation complicated by land rights (land now formally owned by the Nepali government)

Drought and Water Scarcity

- Seasonal water shortages outside of monsoon; snowmelt declining
- Tension between flood risk in monsoon and water deficit in dry season

Lupra Village Seen From Above (Google Earth)



Chapter 2— HUMAN DIMENSION

DEMOGRAPHICS

- Population: approximately 60–100 residents (14 households)
- One of 19 Baragaon villages in Lower Mustang
- Seasonal out-migration common; some families split between Lupra and urban centres

KEY HISTORICAL EVENTS

<i>Period</i>	<i>Event</i>	<i>Theme</i>
12th century	Lama Yangton Tashi Gyaltsen founds Lupra; first monastery built	Religion / Settlement
1846	Current monastery (Yungdrung Phuntsok Ling) rebuilt by Karu Druwang Tenzin Rinche	Culture
Pre-1960s	Trans-Himalayan salt trade active; Lupra on secondary trade corridor	Economy
2017	Major monsoon flash flood destroys large portion of farmland	Hazard
2021	Severe flood damages homes; families displaced for months	Hazard
2020s	Community organises Mustang Bon Homestay Village to sustain culture and income	Tourism / Culture



HEALTH PROFILE

Cold and Altitude

- Hypothermia and respiratory illness are seasonal concerns
- Risk of Acute Mountain Sickness for visitors and returning residents

- School (Chasey Kengtse Hostel, est. 2002) serves children from nearest services in Jomsom
- No resident healthcare facility;

Lupra and surrounding areas; classes nursery to class 8

- Young adults increasingly leaving; permanent population declining

COMMUNITIES & ETHNIC GROUPS

- Primary group: Thakali — indigenous to Lower Mustang; Sino-Tibetan language; combines Nepali and Tibetan cultural traits
- All 14 families observe Bon religion; hereditary lama system means eldest son of each family takes on ritual responsibilities
- The monastery is maintained by villagers themselves rather than resident monks
- HH Menri Tridzin Rinpoche recognised as the chief Bon figure

Nutrition

- Subsistence farming covers basics but dietary diversity is limited
- Flood damage to farmland increases dependence on imported food

Mental Health and Social Stress

- Loss of ancestral homes and farmland to flooding causes significant grief and anxiety
- Out-migration fragments families and social networks
- Bon ritual practice and community decision-making provide psychological grounding
- Uncertainty around relocation is a current community-wide stressor



Lupra Monastery (Bon Gompa)

LIVELIHOODS & AGRICULTURE

- Primary economy: agro-pastoralism (farming + livestock herding)
- Crops: barley, buckwheat, millet, potatoes, kidney beans; orchards of apple, apricot, walnut
- Livestock: dzo, goats, sheep, horses, chickens
- Supplementary income from trekkers using the Annapurna Alternative Trail
- Mustang Bon Homestay Village project offers community homestays to generate economic incentive for youth to stay
- Flooding and soil loss are directly cutting agricultural output

CULTURE, RELIGION & INDIGENOUS KNOWLEDGE

- Bon is a pre-Buddhist spiritual tradition originating in the Zhang Zhung region of western Tibet; practised in Lupa for over 800 years
- Central site: Yungdrung Phuntsok Ling monastery (rebuilt 1846; original founded 12th century)
- Annual five-day masked dance festival each September or October (lunar calendar)
- Key ritual: 'Lu Jins' a Bon exorcism ceremony specific to this tradition
- Gon Phuk ('winter cave') above the village: meditation retreat of the founder, now a small temple
- Circumambulation of sacred sites done counter-clockwise (opposite to Buddhist practice)
- Traditional water management and community decision-making structures still active

SOURCES

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